

Dissertation

Research Projects, Personal Writing.

Judith Orloff

Critique of a Dissertation: Nowhere Man

Skipp, Tracy John

Educational Leadership (2010)

ELC 727 Methods Action Research

Dr. Anna DiStefano

3/11/17

Complete description of the study including the author's line of reasoning

Reading this dissertation was a complete surprise. I chose an Action Research Dissertation that used the autoethnography methodology. In this dissertation, *Nowhere Man: Autoethnographic Reflections on Identity, Family, and Leadership*, Skipp describes the purpose of his self-study to "discover the values and attitudes I model as a leader to support people in doing their best work. Specifically, do I practice leadership Intimacy?"p.viii. One of his goals in this dissertation is to bring the reader into his experience so they can be with him on this journey. In that goal, he succeeded. As I read, I felt as absorbed as when I read a good novel. Chapter One, Context for the Study, begins with a quote from John Lennon and Paul McCartney, which represents why he chose the title Nowhere Man for this work. "Knows not where he's going to; isn't he a bit like you and me?"

Skipp begins by describing his life through his memories, thoughts, and feelings. After a discussion on the history of the University, he describes his upbringing. Being a "military brat," he found solace through his Catholic schooling in the countries where his father was stationed. His writing is deeply personal and arises from one of his five methods of research, Autoethnography as well as a strong desire to heal himself.

The other methods are a 360 assessment, Interviews, Reflective Journaling and Peer Debriefing. He chose autoethnography for this exploration

through his values of Franciscan Roman Catholicism and his life as a senior administrator in a traditional university. To him, those values were in constant conflict. I believed he needed to resolve his daily struggle between “who I see myself to be, and who other students, faculty, and staff perceive me to be (Jourard, 1971)

He suffered every day of his life with pain from rheumatoid arthritis. In the first year of his Doctoral work, his wife who he had been with since he was 15, asked him to “let me go,” I view his choice of using autoethnography, as well as a 360 assessment which included his children, and interviews with his supervisor and peers as a brilliant resolve to his mounting life crises.

And, he certainly achieved the purpose of bringing the reader, me, into his everyday life as I was and am moved to tears, heartbreak, and tenderness as he unswervingly struggles to achieve his goal of “leadership intimacy.” (p.68)

He describes leadership intimacy as authenticity, and authenticity as knowing oneself. He continually identifies with Saint Francis of Assisi, a Catholic saint, medieval monk, and mystic, who also struggled with the question of “who am I” daily.” His deep respect for the values of the Franciscans and his ideas of what a university should be like provides a reflection of his ontology and epistemology.

One of his research questions is “who is training the future generation of leaders? He makes the case that the University is no longer a facility where formal leadership occurs. He believes that leadership intimacy may be a way to offer the leadership mentoring and modeling that he believes is not available presently in universities based on the new economic reality of funding, etc. Operating on a fixed seniority system with a pool of only the most senior staff [faculty] is a very different atmosphere than the corporate fast track model for young executives with obvious, demonstrated talent (Hearn, 2003).

He uses three key concepts to frame his study:

- The philosophy of personalism

- The practice of intimacy
- The role of fatherhood within a family context

Throughout this study, his cognitive dissonance about who he is evident. He works every day as a middle-level administrator in a traditional University and his desire to share the theory of "leadership intimacy," from his personal conflicts. He moves between Marxist and Roman Catholic values in much of his study. The 'Idea of a University' was a village with its priests." Whereas, "the 'Idea of a Modern University' was a town - a one-industry town - with its intellectual oligarchy." (Kerr, 2001p.3) And then he says, "The complex multiversities" have seamlessly morphed into transnational corporations, born of necessity." His choice of becoming a Personalist brings his internal war between his Roman Catholic values and the big business attitude of universities to a halt.

. Personalists maintain that a person, being partly spiritual, is not wholly governed by the laws of physics; and within certain limits, can exercise free will and as such are not completely predictable.

. Personalists accept axiology, or value-theory and disagree with the logical positivists (influenced by science) affirming the absolute value of each person. (Gregg, 1999, pp. 167-168)

His belief of how to be a leader, father, ex-husband, and administrator are reflected in the following quote: "It is through our responses to other persons that we become persons. It is others who challenge, enlighten and enrich us. There is no such thing as an isolated individual Reality is the lived relation. Through sharing in the giving and receiving of mutual being the, "I" becomes real." (Oldham, 1958)

Literature Search and Review

His Literature Review was motivated by a crisis as to whether he was

sufficiently prepared (p. 27) to lead. I find throughout the dissertation, a continuing attempt to prove he is o.k. as a person. He shares many stories about the people he works. The most poignant is a confrontation he has with his supervisor where she tells him because he is not a faculty member, he is like the water boy on the team. "she was also prone to fits of rage." (p.28)

With a dearth of literature on Intimacy Leadership. He explored,

- Visionary Leadership
- Collaborative Leadership
- Reflective Leadership
- Communicative Leadership
- Relational Leadership

After a thorough review of these leadership methodologies, he said, "none of them frame my professional experience or leadership practice (Raelin, 2003). Perhaps this is because traditional leadership is often studied in a business model." Rather, he approached his most coveted mentor, Brother Richard, a Franciscan monk that lived a few blocks away and tended the garden in the church, and spoke to him of what he learned in his literature search,

"I guess I would see leadership in three parts," I explained. "The first part is intimacy with self; you must disclose self to authentically know yourself, and you must know yourself to get to know others. The second part is intimacy with others, from a personalist perspective or philosophy, it relies on relationships to exist. The third part is developmental intimacy; you must give others a safe place to grow and nurture those relationships. We need those relationships to exist. It is a circular flow, a process that we continually go through life."(p.48)

Research Methods

Reflexive poetics: This comes from two similar strategies, reflexive ethnography (Ellis & Bochner, 1996) and anthropological poetics (Brady 1991). Uses internal dialogue, conversations with self to evoke strong feelings in the reader. Visual form of evocative narrative (Bochner & Ellis 1997)

Autoethnography: the Personal style of writing known as narrative inquiry, (Bochner, Ellis, Tillman-Healy, 1997, 1998) "A stream of consciousness like watching a film. An intensely personal format for social science that invites the reader into the mind and thoughts of the researcher." (p.52, 3) Ellis (2004) describes this experience as a collaborative journal between the author and the reader. Krizek (1998) says "in short, we often render our research reports devoid of human emotion and self-reflection. As ethnographers, we experience life, but we write science.' (p.93) Autoethnography, the way Skipp describes it has its roots in phenomenology.

Qualitative research, as a descriptive term, covering several forms of inquiry studying in a social context (Merriam, 1998) with an emphasis on cultural setting.

Data Collection

This section of the critique is the most difficult for me to decipher He believed he could do this study on his own. (Feldman (2003) created four criteria which data collection could take place in autoethnography:

1. Clarity of how data collection will occur
2. Clear descriptions of how to construct the representation from the data. What were the specifics
3. Extend triangulation beyond multiple sources of data to include explorations of various ways to represent the same self-study

4. Provide evidence that the research changed the subject and summarized its value to the profession (27-28)

Although he used a peer debriefer for various discussions about his leadership, I couldn't see any value the in these discussions for middle level administrator/leaders in a most University settings. I certainly saw the value to him personally.

The questions he asked were:

- What values do I lead by?
- What attitudes and practices do I model as a leader:
- Specifically, do I practice leadership intimacy?
- Meaning, what is the appropriate role of interpersonal relationships in developing leaders?

Eight Interviews were recorded and transcribed. A colleague administered the interviews to his children and seven former peers using vignettes and transcribing them. He used the methodology of idea units, and joint-probability of agreement model (Uebersax,)1987, this method is the least complex and “for this reason, the least robust.” (p.90)

The three values that were measured in idea units were: Metanoia, know yourself, Humility, focus on others and Solitude, safe harbor. He scored highest in Solitude, then Humility and then Metanoia. This meant to him that his self-evaluation and the 360 data was congruent using his data collection methods.

I became and still am confused while reading the results and indications of this study. I was unable to find conclusions that were not contradictory. His ideas that were measured, were not the ones I thought he was looking at through the lens of “leadership intimacy,” which was authenticity. The three leadership values that were measured came from the Roman Catholic values he so wanted to instill in his working life at the University.

I believe Tracy John Skipp made a valuable contribution to the literature of Autoethnography. I felt connected through his narrative and as I said earlier was moved from time to time. The other methodologies he used, such as vignettes, and the eight interviews were presented in ways that were both unclear and tedious to me. I was unable to move from the personal aspect, which accomplished his stated goal of taking the reader with him, and the impersonal, universal, research methodology used in the dissertation.

Dissertation

NOWHERE MAN:
AUTOETHNOGRAPHIC REFLECTIONS ON
IDENTITY, FAMILY, AND LEADERSHIP
BY TRACY JOHN SKIPP
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Insight as a Core Mechanism of Mindfulness: An Action research project

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Introduction

There are many benefits to Mindfulness both Eastern (Buddhist based non-conceptual) and Western based Mindfulness. (conceptual)

Western based Mindfulness is taught by Jon Kabot-Zin, whose Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction program has graduated approximately 24,000 participants and over 2000 certified instructors, and Ellen Langer, Harvard Psychology Dept. Mindfulness articles in the database of the American Mindfulness Research Association was 3,403. Zinn said, "Mindfulness is awareness that arises through paying attention, on purpose, in the present moment, non-judgmentally, it's about knowing what is on your mind." Mindfulness in the West is used for stress reduction, physical and psychological illness such as depression, heart disease and more. Purser & Millilo, (2004) The United States 2007 census reported that over 20,000,000 people say they meditate for health reasons.

Western Mindfulness has become mainstream. It is taught in many universities, local yoga schools, some public schools, on line programs. In fact, there is a concentration in the Leadership for Change program at Fielding called Somatics, Phenomenology and Communicative leadership with Valerie Bentz as faculty head.

Mindfulness in corporate life has been increasing over the past few years as well. Chade meng Tan teaches mindfulness at Google and he has a waiting list over six months. His program is called Search Inside Yourself, and is thought to be one of the main reasons Google is the highest rated worldwide employer. (Confino, 2014). Four other large organizations are General Mills, (Gelles,2013), Intel, Aetna, and Goldman Sachs. Aetna estimated that through taking classes in Mindfulness, employee value went up by \$3,000 a year (Gelles,2015) Sally Boyle,

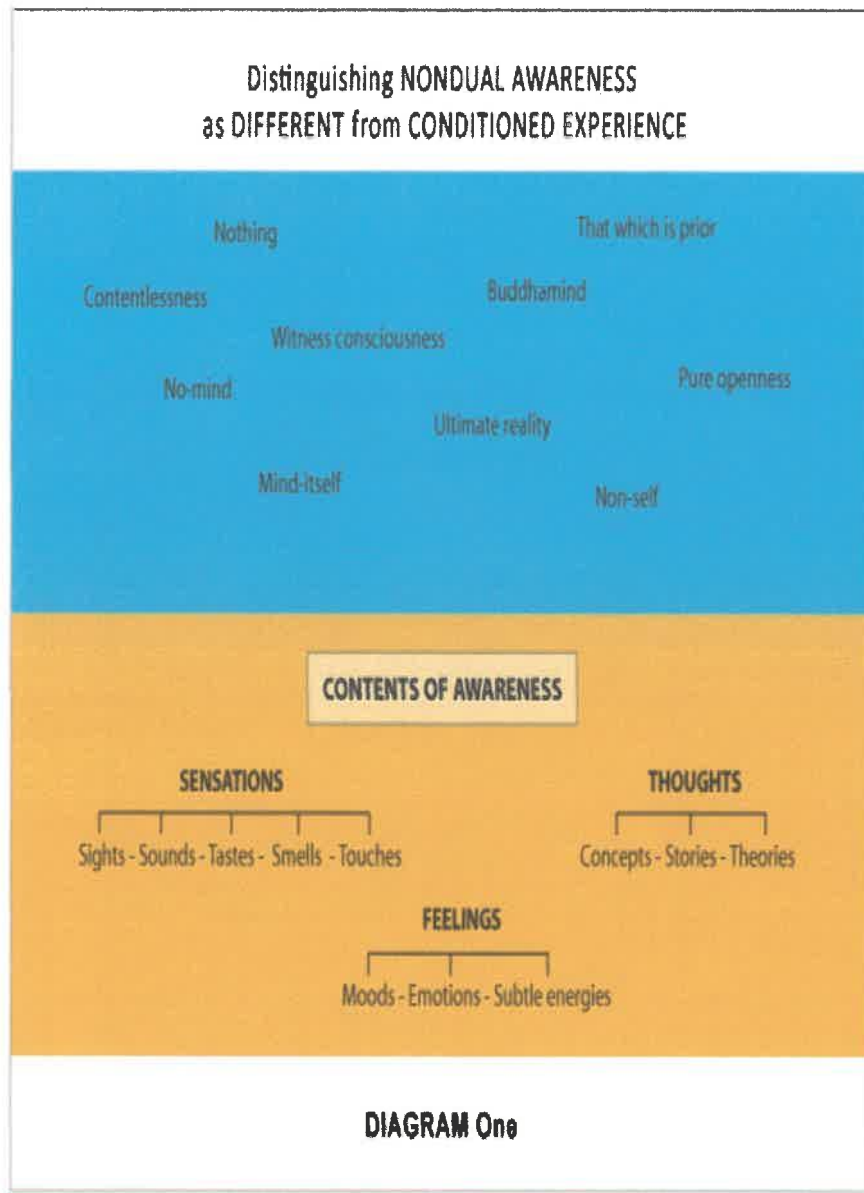
head of human capital management at Goldman Sachs, comments: "In years to come we'll be talking about mindfulness as we talk about exercise now" (Agnew, 2014).

Eastern based (Buddhist) mindfulness has been around for over 2600 years. The practitioner observes the arising and passing away of phenomenon occurring in their experience. "Mindfulness means seeing things as they are, without trying to change them. The point is to dissolve our reactions to disturbing emotions, being careful not to reject the emotion itself." (Bennett-Goleman 2000).

For this paper, I will refer to the terms Mindfulness and Meditation as expressed in the literature, which is that when one is meditating, one is mindful (Hutcherson, C., et al. 2008). I will be exploring non-conceptual mindfulness which is more attuned to the Buddhist definition.

See page 4, Diagram One

Diagram One represents a map of non-conceptual Mindfulness is figure 1 (Fenner,2009.)



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Purser and Milillo (2014) assert Western Mindfulness is easily misappropriated to achieve “employee pacification, institutional power, and maintenance of toxic organizational cultures”. Possibly, this is caused by the focus on results of health and well-being, rather than allowing the rising and falling of phenomenon which allows space. (source) They suggest that non-conceptual mindfulness, more attuned to the Buddhist definition, (Fenner, 2009) allows the practitioner to transfer their knowledge from specific tasks to a more generalized learning that overrides specificity (Slagter, Davidson, & Lutz, 2011, p. 2). They call this this mindfulness-as-process. This definition of mindfulness “provides approaches and tools in educational conditions for a sustainable and truly empowering learning.” (Lanestrand 2012). This is important to me as a research project. The idea and experience of sustainability and empowered learning through the experience of Mindfulness with an action research component as well as a spiritual dimension is my personal goal for my dissertation.

Purser & Millilo also assert, no matter what the individual practice, the benefits to relationships, health and wellness are well researched. Yet, the core mechanisms involved in mindfulness practices are not clearly understood. It is my assertion that Insight is a core mechanism in the practice of Mindfulness. This research project will use the Buddhist definition of Mindfulness and investigate Insight as a core mechanism to Mindfulness.

In this study, Insight is defined as “awareness of the origin of your beliefs, values and points of view; knowing your truth, ontology and epistemology is personal, not universal.

“(Orloff six principles of mindfulness 2015)

The following areas will be presented in this paper:

- Questions being addressed

- Research Approach
- Research Design
- Setting(s)
- Participants, recruitment, selection, roles
- Data Gathering/Procedures/Instruments
- Plan for analysis of data.

Research Questions

The purpose of this study is to investigate the following assumptions and questions:

- Does being insightful in personal day to day activities and in relationships lead to a deeper level of mindfulness?
- Does experiencing insight lead to behavior benefiting the participant and the people they interact with on a regular basis?
- Does experiencing insight reduce blame as a function of projection.

Projection as a resistance to insight is a habit everyone learns as a child. It is so ingrained that most of us think it is a natural part of who we are. However, it is not intrinsic to our nature, but learned. It happens when people do not approve of their feelings and fool themselves into believing the feelings are coming from someone else. When we project, we see ourselves as victims of someone else's actions rather than being the author of our own experience. To be truly self-aware it is necessary to see ourselves as being responsible for our own experience (Malin & Grotstein 1966;) (Orloff & Doubleday 1991)

Research Approach

I will use narrative inquiry, a qualitative action research methodology, for this study. Through narrative inquiry, a participant's experience is interpreted and made personally meaningful (Clandinin, Pushor, & Orr, 2007, p. 22). It is a story and a way of thinking about experience (Clandinin et al., 2007, p. 22). Narrative inquirers turn from one way of knowing the world to an understanding that there are multiple ways of knowing and understanding human experience (Clandinin, 2006, p. 25). I think Narrative Inquiry methodology will allow for a more historically accurate interview through the in-depth interview itself. The connection between the researcher, myself, and the participant will bring forth data not otherwise elicited.

"Narrative is both a qualitative research method and way of theorizing psychological and social phenomena" (Carless & Douglas, 2017, p. 307). Narrative inquiry is first and foremost a way of understanding experience. It is also a research methodology. "It is, then, both a view of the phenomena of people's experiences and a methodology for narratively inquiring into experience and thus allows for the intimate study of individuals' experiences over time and in context" (Given, 2008, p. 542). This is important in analyzing the data.

Narrative inquiry needs to be authentic and transparent. The idea of the researcher's voice and the voice of the participant needs to be faithful to the historical and future context of the study. Each participant is telling their story as reflected to the researcher who also has a voice. "to live authentically, you must follow your own way" (Taylor, 1997). Narratives may provide a fundamental connection for action research. Creswell, 2005 stated, "they emphasize close collaboration with the participant-storyteller" (p.?).

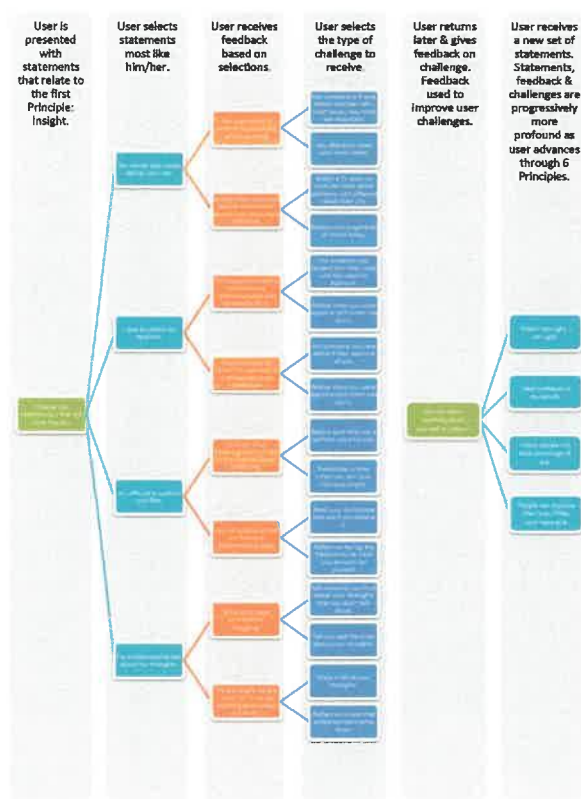
As each participant shares their story, I think they will be motivated to continue telling more of their story over time. I experience when people are allowed and encouraged to share their story, more of the emotional underpinnings are elicited and a more holistic approach can be offered.

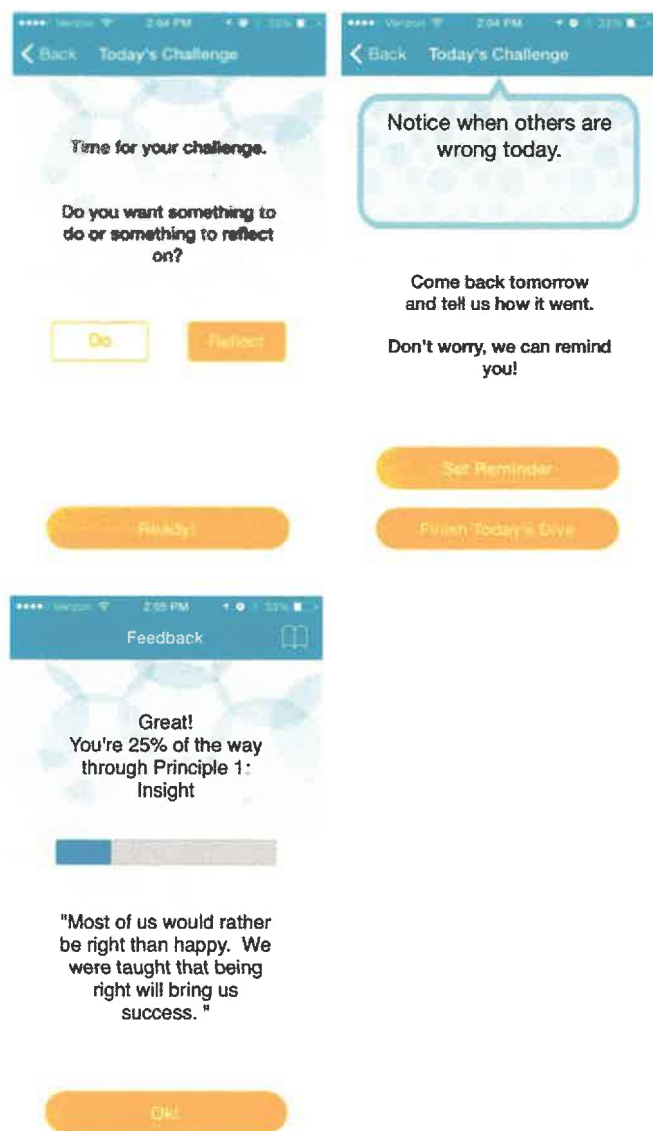
Research Design

The design is based on narrative inquiry, is qualitative and will use surveys, in-depth interviews and focus group exit interviews. Twenty participants will be given an in-depth questionnaire and interview to begin with. This will be followed by an email based daily survey for 28 days. The participants will receive a four-question survey each day and based on the responses received, the participant will be asked to make a choice between an action and a reflection. Both the action and the reflection will be based on the principle of insight.

The next day, the participant will be asked to share the results of their choice and this will be categorized by an algorithm specifically designed for this study. Each participant will participate in a focus group exit interview following the 28-day email survey. The actions and reflections the participants are asked to complete are based on previous focus groups and a 1000-person questionnaire previously administered. The four mockups below are examples of how this information was used in 2015 with my organization Radical Choices, Inc., to create an

application for a mobile phone. This action research project is the next step in testing the validity of insight as a core mechanism of Mindfulness.





We will use Survey Monkey and Survey Gizmo to collect the contact and eligibility information from potential participants. Survey Monkey has implemented a freely available system that securely implements the desired features: the data is encrypted during transmission using <http://www.surveygizmo.com/survey-blog/online-survey-hipaa-safe-harbor-certification/> the secure https protocol, and the data is stored in a database which only the research team, myself and a personal assistant, can access. The data is HIPAA compliant.

Research Setting

Boulder and the surrounding areas are steeped in Mindfulness classes and practitioners. The in-depth interview and focus group exit interviews will take place at an art studio where I teach mindfulness classes, the Hillel meeting room at the University of Colorado and on Skype and Zoom. I wish to make the setting as comfortable as possible for the participants.

Research Participants

Participants will be adults ages 18 – 75. They will be recruited from social media such as LinkedIn, Facebook and Constant Contact. I have 1100 followers on LinkedIn, 880 followers on Facebook and 550 possible participants on Constant Contact, who I have sent content of this nature to over the past few years.

Participants will also be recruited from people who have asked to work with me. Participants will speak English as their first language, as the concept of insight needs to be clear from the beginning. Participants will have minimal prior experience with mindfulness practices and will

have access to the internet. Possible participants in the study will be excluded for any of the following reasons:

1. If they have participated in any mindfulness training experiments in the past,
2. if they have low interest in mindfulness training, as we wish to run this mindfulness study only with participants interested in this practice

A web form will be used to identify eligible, interested participants. The flyers and postings on the web form will refer potential participants to a website which has more information about this study, exclusion criteria, and a form asking for contact information and eligibility information. Prior to participation, all possible participants will be given an approved consent form that contains all relevant details. The online form in no way replaces the approved consent form; it is merely a tool to facilitate the identification of eligible candidates

Data Gathering/Instruments/Procedures

Participants will engage in an in-depth interview. There are 63 questions in this interview guide. This is an opening to the in-depth interview and may not be followed as written.

Autobiography Question (Please check most accurate answer)		
1. My father saw himself as successful		
2. I saw him as successful		
3. My mother saw herself as successful		
4. I saw her as successful		
5. In the evenings when my family was together, it was enjoyable		
6. In my family people spoke openly about money		
7. In my family people spoke openly about relationships		
8. In my family people spoke openly about problems and challenges		
9. In my family mistakes were punished		
10. In my family mistakes were an opportunity for learning		
11. I felt close to my parents		
12. My parents felt close to me		
13. In my family, I was usually a source of pride		
14. In my family, I was usually invisible		
15. In my family, I was usually a clown		

16. In my family, I was usually a scapegoat		
17. In my family, I was usually a problem		
18. In a group, I am usually a leader		
19. In a group, I am usually a follower		
20. In a group, I am usually anonymous		
21. In a group, I am usually a scapegoat		
22. I am presently in a romantic relationship. If yes, please continue, if no, go to question 28.		
23. In my current relationship, I am the finance person		
24. In my current relationship, I am the nurturer		
25. In my current relationship, I am the leader		
26. In my current relationship, I am the follower		
27. In my current relationship, I am invisible		
28. I presently am working. If yes continue, if no, go to question 33		
29. I am happy in my work		
30. I have challenges in my work situation		
31. I have opportunities to grow in my work		
32. I have trouble keeping work		
33. The next three questions are about both personal and professional relationships.		
34. I am satisfied in my relationships		
35. I have challenges in my relationships		
36. I have trouble sustaining positive relationships		
37. I know how to play		
38. I know how to communicate clearly		
39. I know how to listen to others		
40. I can feel love for others		
41. I can feel loved by others		
42. I can feel angry		
43. I can feel worried		
44. I can feel sad		
45. I can feel joy		
46. I can feel despair		
47. I can feel proud		
48. I can feel embarrassed		
49. I trust easily		
50. I feel strongly about family		
51. I feel strongly about my country		
52. I feel strongly about poverty		
53. I feel strongly about the environment		
54. I feel strongly about the future		
55. I feel strongly about child abuse		
56. I feel strongly about domestic violence		
57. I feel strongly about homelessness		
58. I feel strongly about veterans		

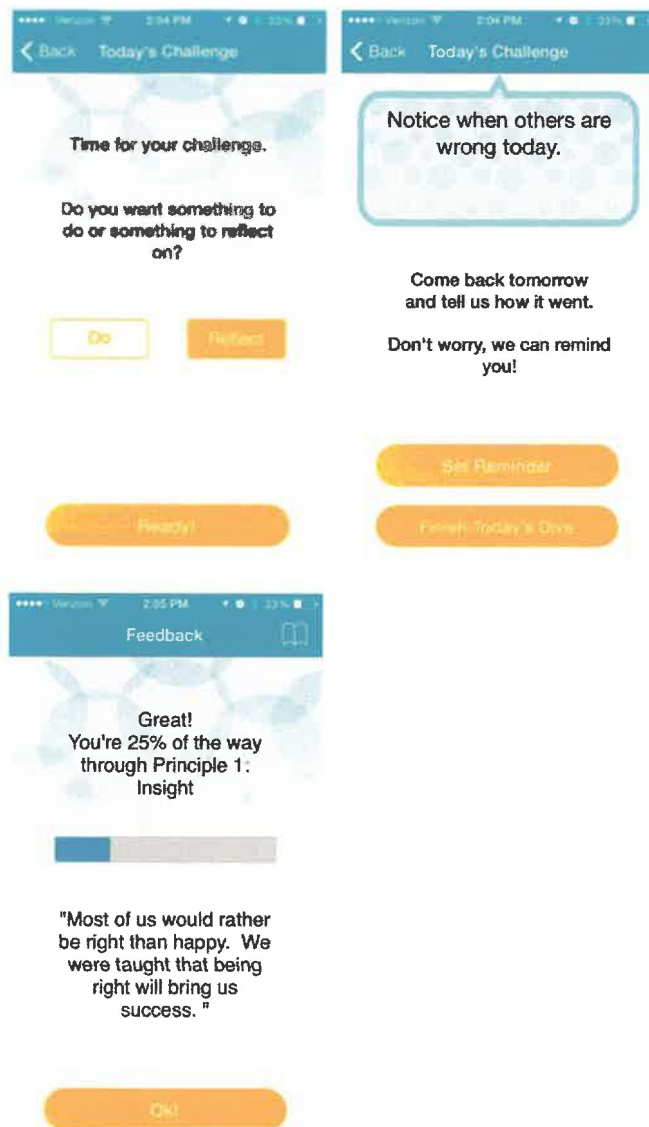
59. I feel strongly about the elderly		
60. I have trouble feeling in general		
61. I have a spiritual path		
62. I believe people are basically good		
63. I believe people can work together to change the world		

(Radical Choices, Orloff&Doubleday2015)

Some of this information was in the research design section of the project and may be repetitive. Participants will receive a daily email (28 days) asking them to respond to four statements, choosing those that they believe are most representative of how they see themselves and the world. Participants can choose as many or as few as they wish. These emails will come through a Survey software. After they answer the questions they will be asked to either reflect on their response or do an action connected to something evoked by their answers. When they return to their email accounts the next day, they will find another email, asking them whether they chose an action or a reflection. The participant will answer how the reflection or action was experienced by them and they will send that response in a return email.

This action research study is the next step in testing the validity of insight as a core mechanism of Mindfulness.

The mockups below are examples of how this information was used in 2015 with my organization Radical Choices, Inc., to create an application for a mobile phone.



Examples of four statements that refer to insight that the participant will respond to each day by choosing those he identifies with.

Insight I don't want certain people to know my weaknesses, because they can take advantage of me.
Insight I know what I believe.
Insight It's too risky to talk about my weaknesses.
Insight I know when I'm triggered, and how to get out of it.

How are you taken advantage of?
Imagine, for two hours, that everyone
Notice how often you judge others as
What do you do when you're feeling t

Plan for Analyzing the Data

The narrative inquiry approach used in this study values collaboration and relationships.

Narrative inquiry is not just a research method, but rather a process of meaning making that encompasses 3 major spheres of inquiry: the scientific (physical), the symbolic (human experience) and the sacred (metaphysical).

At the heart of narrative inquiry is doubt. Inquiries are often messy, blurred contradictory and chaotic. Narrative inquiry becomes coherent after the fact as data is analyzed and may then seem reasonable. Knowing that the data will be incomplete can bring a sense of appreciation to this study exploring insight as a core mechanism for understanding mindfulness.

Asserting that narrative inquiry is more dependent on the questions asked not method. Bruner, (1996) discussed the art of keeping question alive is as important as receiving clear answers. He said, "Good questions are ones that pose dilemmas, subvert obvious or canonical "truths," force incongruities upon our attention." (p. 127)

With that wisdom in mind, and those three areas noted, my plan for analyzing the data garnered during this study includes:

- Transcription of meetings of in-depth interviews. The interview data will be examined in terms of key themes that relate to insight in the three areas discussed by Bruner, the physical, symbolic and the sacred.
- Field notes of my experiences during the in-depth interviews as relating to insight categorized in the same three areas.
- Video of focus groups lasting 60 to 90 minutes. I expect to have two focus groups where the following questions will be asked,
 1. What changes in attitudes toward yourself and others did you experience during the last 5 weeks?
 2. Were there any challenges or reflections that did/didn't work for you?
 3. What insights did you discover about yourself or others during the past five weeks?
 4. What feedback and insights can you share with me about this study?
 5. What have you learned during this time that was not anticipated?

I will discuss and analyze the participant responses to the 28-day survey, and the self-reporting during the focus groups at the end of the study. I will examine the data to see differences in the participant's personal experience of Insight and the resultant behavior choices they make during the time of the study.

- I will ask each participant to keep an e-journal of their experiences. The e-journal will be shared during the focus groups and be looked at for consistency with the in-depth interviews and the 28-day survey.

- Each participant will be given a coaching session on mindfulness if they complete the study, plus a \$25.00 bonus.

Conclusion

This study is the first step in my dissertation and is meant to discover how insight is a core mechanism for Mindfulness. It is intended to reveal the resultant space insight allows to observe and diminish negative childhood conditioning. This can occur through the experience of noticing reactive states and negative emotions while allowing them to come and go in day to day experiences.

The results will be disseminated to practitioners of Mindfulness and may be submitted for publication in an appropriate journal. I feel it is too early to go further. Based on the results of this study, I will determine the next steps to take.

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